

Distributor Portal

Research findings, viability assessment, and a staged build plan

Prepared for Harish Sharma • Cerebyl (Pharma BMT) • 3 August 2026

Verdict: build it — but not as first described.

A distributor portal is a genuinely strong fit for a PCD franchise business, and a strong sales differentiator for Cerebyl. However, **adoption is the entire risk, not engineering**. A password-protected app maximises friction for exactly the users least likely to overcome it.

Recommendation: ship a **no-login tokenised portal first** (~2 weeks), reusing the `/track/$token` pattern already live in the product. Add accounts only once the links show real usage. **Do not build in-app chat at all.**

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1. What you asked for

Restating the brief so we are working from the same thing. A distributor- and client-facing side of the app, where a party of a pharma company can:

- bullet browse the product list and current offers
- bullet place orders themselves
- bullet chat with their assigned rep inside the app
- bullet receive notifications
- bullet log in with an account, where the pharma company manages the email and password from that party's profile in the CRM

You described it as a rough idea and asked whether it is viable before committing. This document answers that, then lays out how it should be built.

2. What the research says

The headline numbers are discouraging, and worth taking seriously.

Finding	Figure	Implication
B2B ecommerce projects that underperform or fail outright	80–95%	The base rate is poor. Assume failure unless actively designed against.
B2B portals that under-deliver after launch because customers do not use them	65%	The failure is adoption, not technology.
B2B buyers who prefer ordering through digital commerce	83%	Latent demand is real where the experience is good.
Buyers who would switch to a competitor with better online ordering	90%	Doing nothing is not risk-free either.
Order volume that shifts to the portal where adoption succeeds	60–80%	The upside, when it lands, is large.

Why portals fail

The consistent finding is that portals fail not because the technology does not work, but because companies assume buyers will simply arrive, digitise a process that was already broken, overlook operations, and neglect internal adoption. In other words: the build is the easy part.

The WhatsApp problem

In Indian wholesale distribution specifically, WhatsApp is the incumbent and it is winning on familiarity. It is already part of the retailer's daily workflow, requires learning nothing, and reaches adoption levels dedicated ordering apps routinely fail to match. The counter-argument is equally true: WhatsApp gives you no structured orders, no live pricing, no order history, and no inventory truth. Every order arrives as free text somebody has to re-key.

The strategic read: you do not win by competing with WhatsApp for attention. You win by meeting the distributor *inside* WhatsApp — a link they tap — and doing the structured work on your side of that link.

3. Why your situation beats the averages

Three structural advantages make the generic failure rate a poor predictor here.

PCD is a franchise relationship, not a marketplace

Propaganda Cum Distribution grants marketing and distribution rights for a territory, usually on a monopoly basis. That is real leverage. A pharma company can tell its franchise partners that orders now come through the portal, and make it stick, because the partner's territory rights depend on the relationship. A marketplace can never compel that. This single fact moves you materially off the 65% base rate.

Your customer is the pharma company, not the distributor

This is the most commonly missed point. Cerebyl is sold to the pharma company. "Your distributors get their own branded portal" is a strong differentiator in that sale *regardless of how heavily distributors use it*. The feature earns its keep in the pitch even at moderate adoption. That changes the ROI calculation completely versus a consumer product where usage is the only value.

The ordering loop is repetitive and therefore automatable

PCD distributors reorder largely the same products on a monthly cycle. That is the ideal shape for self-service: the highest-value interaction is not browsing a catalogue, it is **repeating the last order in two taps**. Most portals bury this. It should be the first thing on the screen.

4. What you already have

An audit of the codebase found that a meaningful part of this feature already exists, and that the product has already reached for distributor-facing surfaces twice.

Existing capability	Where	Relevance
Tokenised public route, no login	src/routes/track.\$token.tsx, backed by an RPC	This is the exact pattern the recommended v1 extends. Proven, shipped, working.
Per-party negotiated pricing	party_rates + use-party-rates.ts	The hardest part of B2B pricing is already built. A distributor can be shown their own rate.
Share to WhatsApp	share-sheet.tsx, order-share.ts (wa.me)	Distribution channel already in place. Links reach the distributor where they already are.
Reorder tracking	use-orders.ts — last invoice date per party	The data behind repeat-order already exists.
Feature entitlements (two-gate)	company_features: allowed / enabled	The portal can be sold as a paid tier with no new infrastructure.
Per-company white-label branding	use-domain-branding.ts (Phase E)	The portal can carry the pharma company's branding, not Cerebyl's.
Branded Android app	mobile/ (shipped 3 Aug 2026)	A distributor build can reuse the same shell. Same APK, different UI by role.

Two of these — the tokenised tracking page and WhatsApp sharing — exist because distributors *already* need information from the system. They are workarounds for a portal that does not exist yet. That is real evidence of demand, from your own product, and it is stronger than any industry statistic in this document.

5. The architectural finding that shapes everything

Every RLS policy in the application resolves tenancy through `current_company_id()`, which reads the `profiles` table.

If a distributor were given an ordinary profile row, they would immediately inherit access to every lead, every other party, every order, and staff salary data for that company. A single misconfigured policy would expose the entire CRM to an external customer.

The safe design follows directly from this. Distributor accounts must be a **separate identity**: an auth user plus a row in a new `party_users` table, and deliberately **no** `profiles` row.

The consequence is that `current_company_id()` returns `NULL` for a distributor, and every existing policy of the form `company_id = current_company_id()` is then false. They see nothing by default. Access becomes an explicit allow-list rather than a subtraction from full access. **That is fail-closed, which is the only acceptable default when the user is outside the organisation.**

Two supporting facts were verified: there is **no trigger creating a profile on signup**, and **self-signup is not enabled** — accounts are created by admins through an edge function. So nothing can accidentally grant a distributor a staff profile.

What a distributor may never see

Worth stating explicitly, because it becomes the RLS test suite: leads, other parties, any other party's orders or dues, stock levels, transporters, staff and salary data, internal notes, cost prices and margins, and anything belonging to another company.

6. Three ways to build it, compared

	A. Tokenised links (no login)	B. Full accounts	C. Hybrid, staged
How it works	Each party gets a permanent secret link, sent over WhatsApp. Opens their catalogue, rates, dues, order history, repeat-order.	Each party gets an email and password managed by the company. Full portal, notifications, app login.	Ship A first. Add B for parties that show usage, keeping A alive for the rest.
Adoption friction	Almost none — one tap from a chat they already read	High — install, remember password, support calls	Lowest first, rising only where earned
Build effort	~2 weeks	~6–8 weeks	~2 weeks, then ~4–5 weeks
Security surface	Small: one revocable token, read-mostly	Large: external authenticated users on the CRM database	Grows only when justified
Support burden on you	Near zero	Ongoing password and access issues routed through the company to you	Deferred and proportional
Notifications	Not possible — push needs an installed app	Full push notifications	Later, where it pays
Sales pitch strength	Good	Strongest	Strong immediately, strongest later

	A. Tokenised links (no login)	B. Full accounts	C. Hybrid, staged
Measures real demand	Yes, cheaply	Only after the full spend	Yes, before the spend
The decisive argument for staging: if a distributor will not tap a link inside a WhatsApp message they are already reading, they will certainly never install an app and remember a password. Option A therefore tests the riskiest assumption in the whole plan for a fraction of the cost — and if it works, it has already delivered most of the value.			

7. Recommended path, phase by phase

Phase A — Tokenised party portal (about 2 weeks)

No login. Extends the existing `/track/$token` pattern.

- bullet **Secure per-party token** — long random value, stored hashed, revocable and rotatable from the party's profile in the CRM. Treated as a capability: whoever holds the link has access, so it must be revocable in one click.
- bullet **Catalogue at their price** — products with the party's negotiated rate from `party_rates`, falling back to the standard rate. Cost prices and margins are never exposed by the underlying function.
- bullet **Repeat last order** — the single highest-value action. Pre-filled from their last invoice, editable, two taps to submit.
- bullet **Order request, not an invoice** — submissions land as a request for the rep to confirm. A distributor must never be able to create a tax invoice directly.
- bullet **Dues and ledger** — outstanding balance, ageing, and recent payments. Reduces payment chasing.
- bullet **Order status** — generalising what `/track` already does for a single order.
- bullet **Message rep** — a button that opens WhatsApp with order context prefilled. Not a chat inbox.
- bullet **Company-branded** — reuses Phase E white-label branding so it looks like the pharma company's own portal.

Phase B — Accounts, only if Phase A shows usage (about 4–5 weeks)

- bullet `party_users` table and `current_party_id()` helper, with no profiles row (section 5).
- bullet Account management inside the party's profile in the CRM: create login, change email, reset password, deactivate — reusing the existing `admin-create-user` / `admin-update-user` edge function pattern.
- bullet Explicit allow-list RLS policies, plus an automated test suite that asserts a distributor cannot read leads, other parties, stock, staff, or another company's data.
- bullet Notifications: order confirmed, dispatched, payment received, new offer.
- bullet Distributor login inside the existing branded Android app — the same APK, with the UI chosen by role.

Phase C — Depth, once it is genuinely in use

- bullet Offers and schemes as a first-class object, with validity windows and per-party targeting.
- bullet Order approval workflow, credit-limit checks at submission time.
- bullet Statement and rate-list downloads (the PDF machinery already exists).
- bullet Multiple contacts per distributor, each with their own access.

Decision gate between A and B: agree the number now, before building. A reasonable bar is that a meaningful share of active parties open their link at least monthly, and that some orders arrive through it, within six weeks of rollout. If that does not happen, Phase B would be building on sand — and you will have learned it for two weeks of work instead of eight.

8. What not to build, and why

In-app chat with reps

This is the one part of the brief worth arguing against directly. Distributors and reps already message each other on WhatsApp continuously. An in-app inbox does not replace that habit; it competes with it and loses. The failure mode is not merely that it goes unused — it is worse than that. **A message sitting unread in an app nobody opens is a missed order**, and the rep will not know it exists.

Build a **Message rep** button instead: it opens WhatsApp with the party, the rep's number, and the relevant order context prefilled. It is a few hours of work rather than weeks, it uses the wa.me plumbing already in the codebase, and it lands where the conversation genuinely happens.

Revisit only if a specific need appears that WhatsApp cannot serve — for example a regulated audit trail of order-related communication.

A distributor-created invoice

Distributor submissions must be **order requests** that a rep confirms. Letting an external party create a tax invoice directly is a financial-control problem, not a convenience feature, and it would undermine the credit-limit and dues logic already in the system.

9. What actually drives usage

If effort has to be cut, cut from the bottom of this list, not the top. The ordering here reflects the repetitive monthly reorder cycle that defines PCD distribution.

Priority	Capability	Why it matters
1	Repeat last order in two taps	The core PCD loop. Most portals bury it; it should be the first thing on the screen.
2	Their negotiated rate, not the list rate	A rate list that is not their rate is worse than useless — it erodes trust immediately.
3	Live dues and ledger	Removes the most frequent and most awkward phone call in the relationship.
4	Order status	The question reps answer most often.
5	Product catalogue and offers	Genuinely useful, but browsing is not the job to be done.
6	Notifications	Only meaningful once an app is installed. Phase B at the earliest.

10. Risks and open decisions

Risk	Severity	Mitigation
Distributors simply do not use it	High	Phase A tests this for two weeks of work instead of eight. Decision gate before Phase B.
Support burden shifts to you	Medium	Tokenised links have almost no support surface. Accounts do — defer them until earned.

Risk	Severity	Mitigation
External users on the CRM database	High	No profiles row, so all existing policies fail closed. Explicit allow-list plus an automated cross-tenant isolation test suite.
A leaked link exposes one party's data	Medium	Treat the token as a capability: hashed at rest, revocable and rotatable in one click, and never granting write access to financial records.
Pricing exposure	Medium	The catalogue function returns only sellable fields. Cost price and margin must never leave the database.
Scope creep into a second product	Medium	The portal is a thin read-mostly surface over existing data. It is not a second CRM.

Decisions needed from you

- bullet **Order semantics** — confirmed assumption: a distributor submission is a *request* that a rep confirms, never a direct invoice. Flag now if you want it otherwise.
- bullet **Price visibility** — should a distributor see their negotiated rate, or only MRP? Recommendation: their rate, because a wrong price destroys trust in the whole portal.
- bullet **Stock visibility** — show availability, or hide it? Recommendation: hide exact quantities, show only in stock / limited / unavailable.
- bullet **Credit limit** — should the portal block a submission that would breach the party's credit limit, or accept it and flag it for the rep? Recommendation: accept and flag, so the rep keeps the commercial judgement.
- bullet **The Phase A to B gate** — agree the usage bar now, while it is still a neutral decision.

Sources

Kibo Commerce, *Why B2B Digital Portals Fail* • Shopaccino, *WhatsApp vs B2B Portal, 2026* • Orderwerks, *B2B Ordering Portal for Wholesale Distributors* • Orderchamp, *How manual B2B orders stall wholesale growth* • Sunray Datalinks, *WhatsApp Order Management for Distributors*. Codebase findings are from a direct audit of the leadenthrilla repository on 3 August 2026.